

Skills Development for Adolescent Girls

Investment case, East Java, Indonesia

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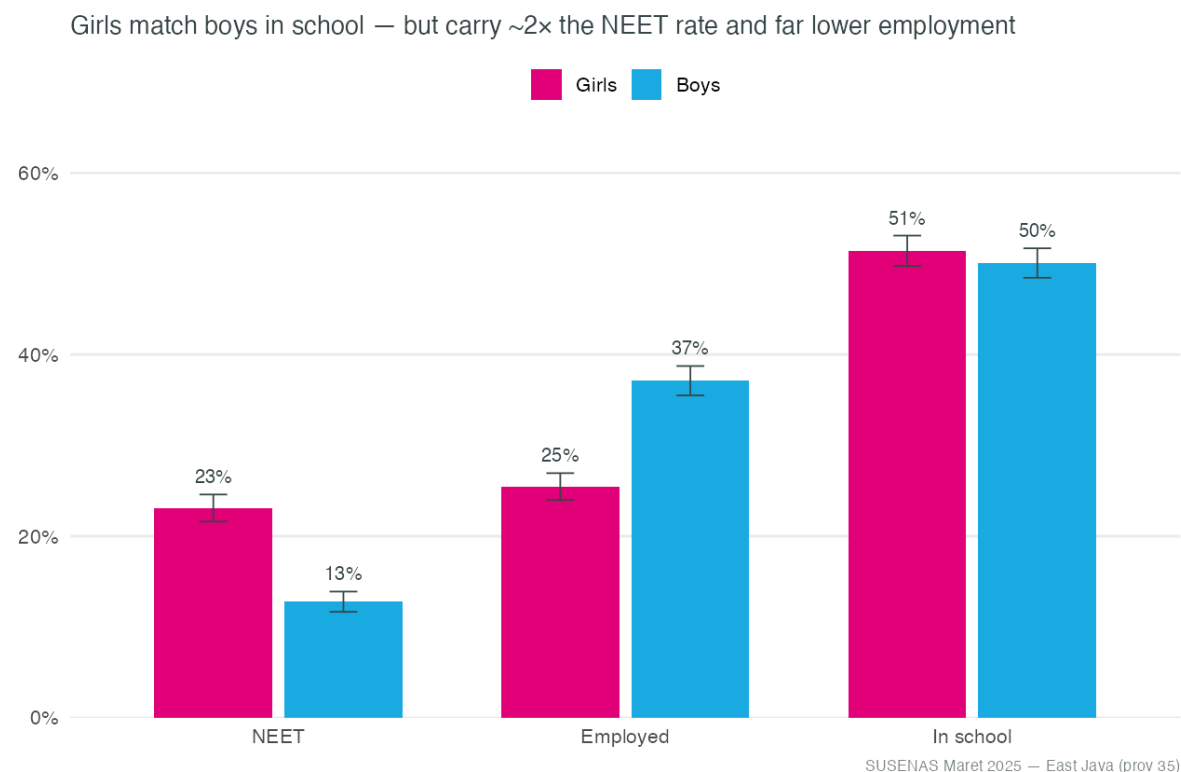
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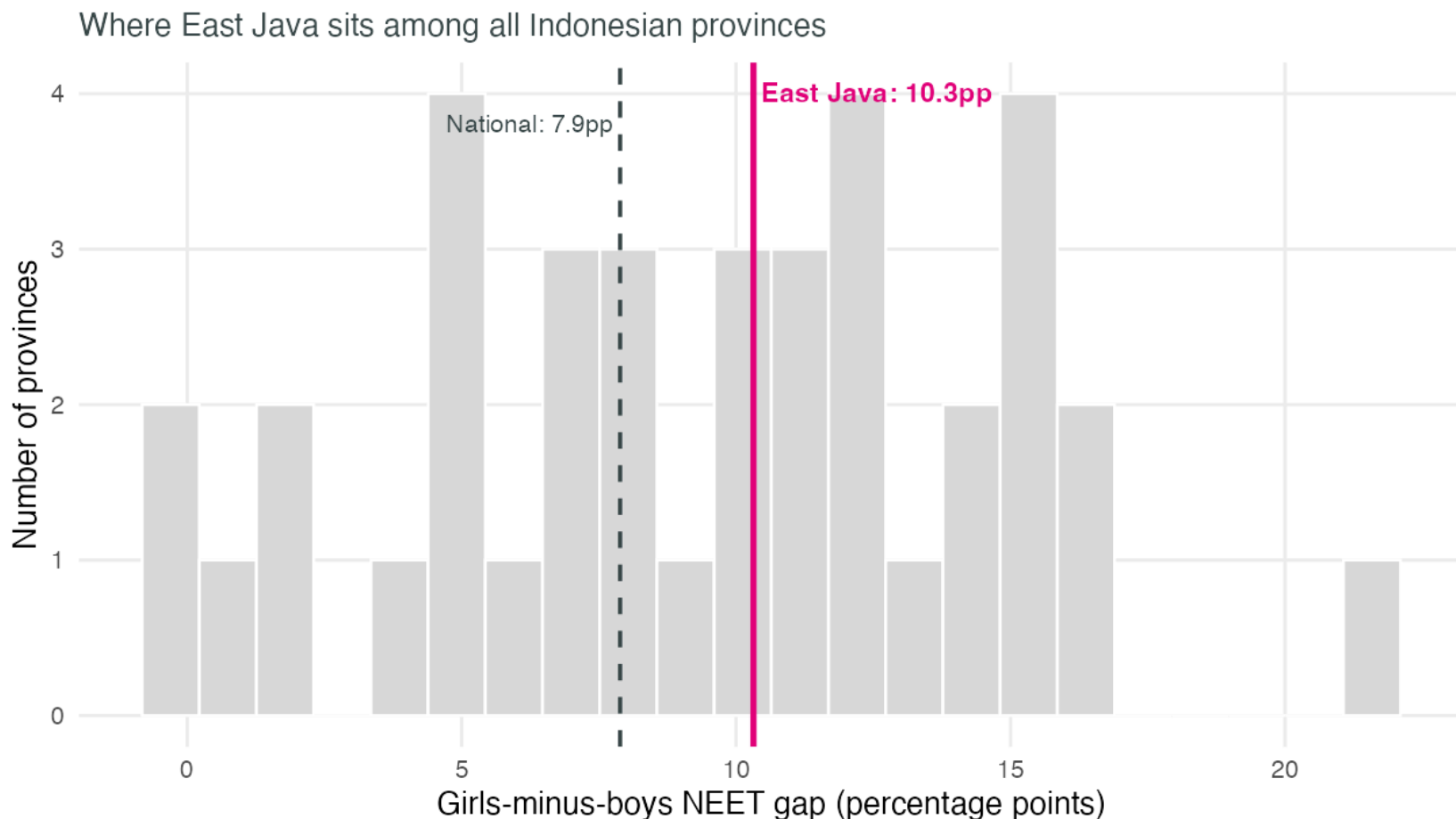
1 • The problem

Girls attend school at the same rate as boys, but their NEET rate is close to double



Girls 15–24: 51% in school (boys 50%), 23% NEET (boys 13%), 25% employed (boys 37%). The gap opens at the transition out of school. SUSENAS Maret 2025, survey-weighted, 95% CIs.

East Java's NEET gender gap is wider than the national average



SUSENAS Maret 2025, all provinces, survey-weighted; adolescents 15-24

Girls-minus-boys NEET gap: 10.3 points in East Java against 7.9 points nationally. Same survey, same definition, all provinces.

The gap costs an estimated USD 4.1 billion in forgone lifetime productivity

Forgone lifetime productivity from the NEET gender gap

Excess NEET girls (10.3pp gap above the boys' rate) x present value of lifetime earnings

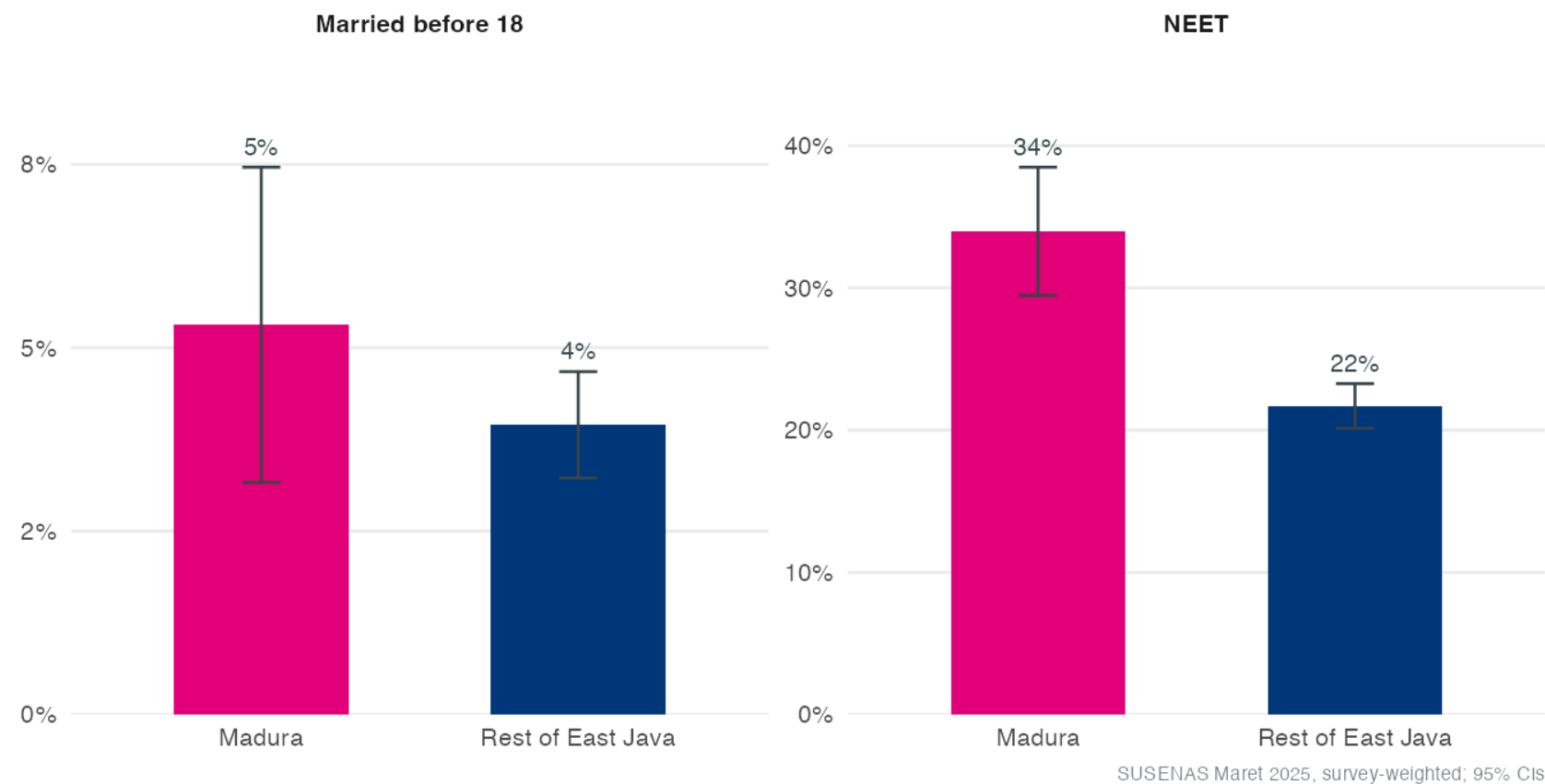


SUSENAS Maret 2025 — East Java (prov 35)

About 288,000 girls are NEET in excess of the boys' rate. Each would be expected to earn about USD 14,100 more over a working lifetime (present value) if she had the boys' NEET rate.

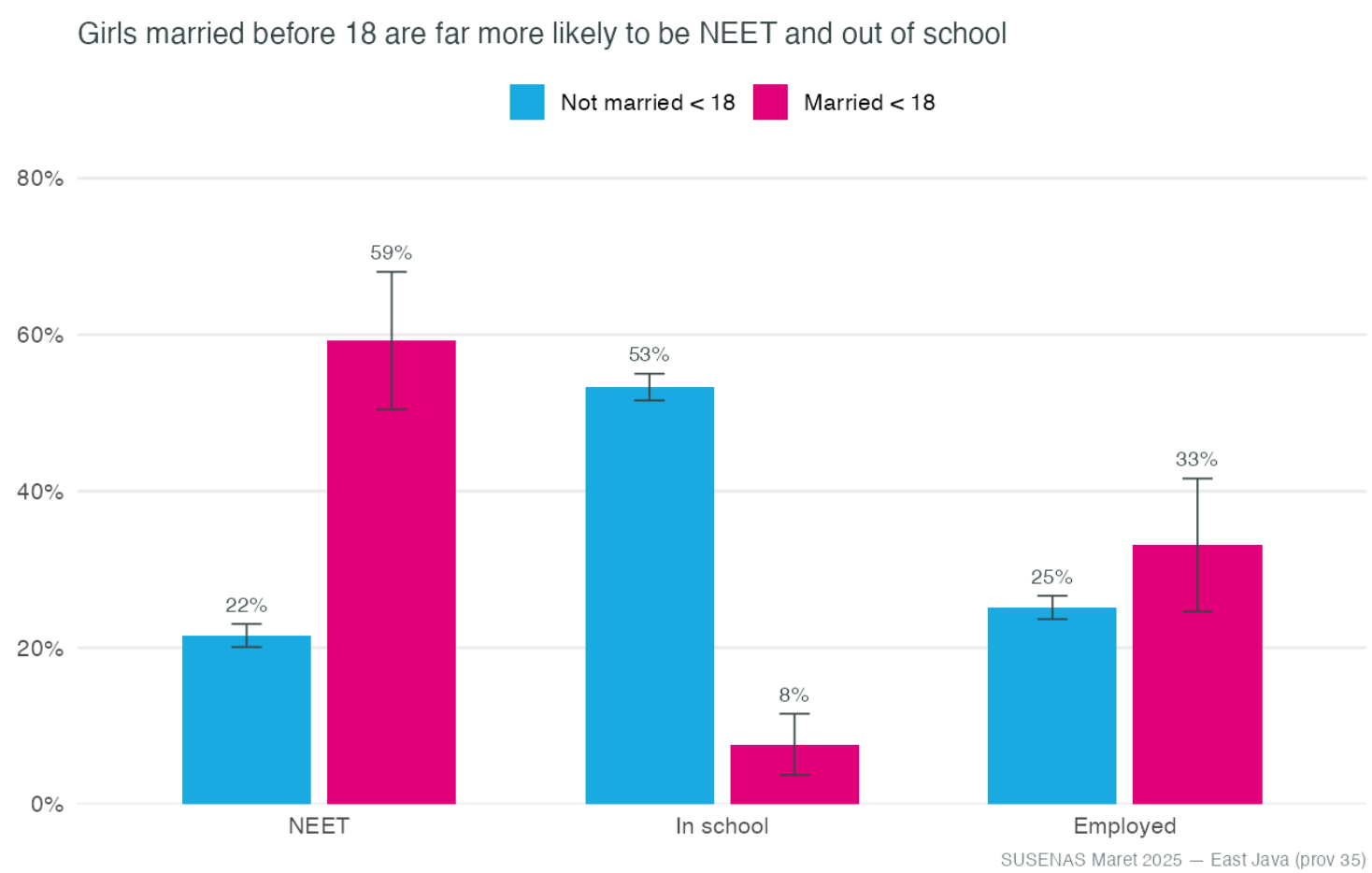
Madura has higher NEET for girls and boys, with a similar gender gap

Girls 15-24: Madura (Bangkalan, Sampang, Pamekasan, Sumenep) vs rest of East Java

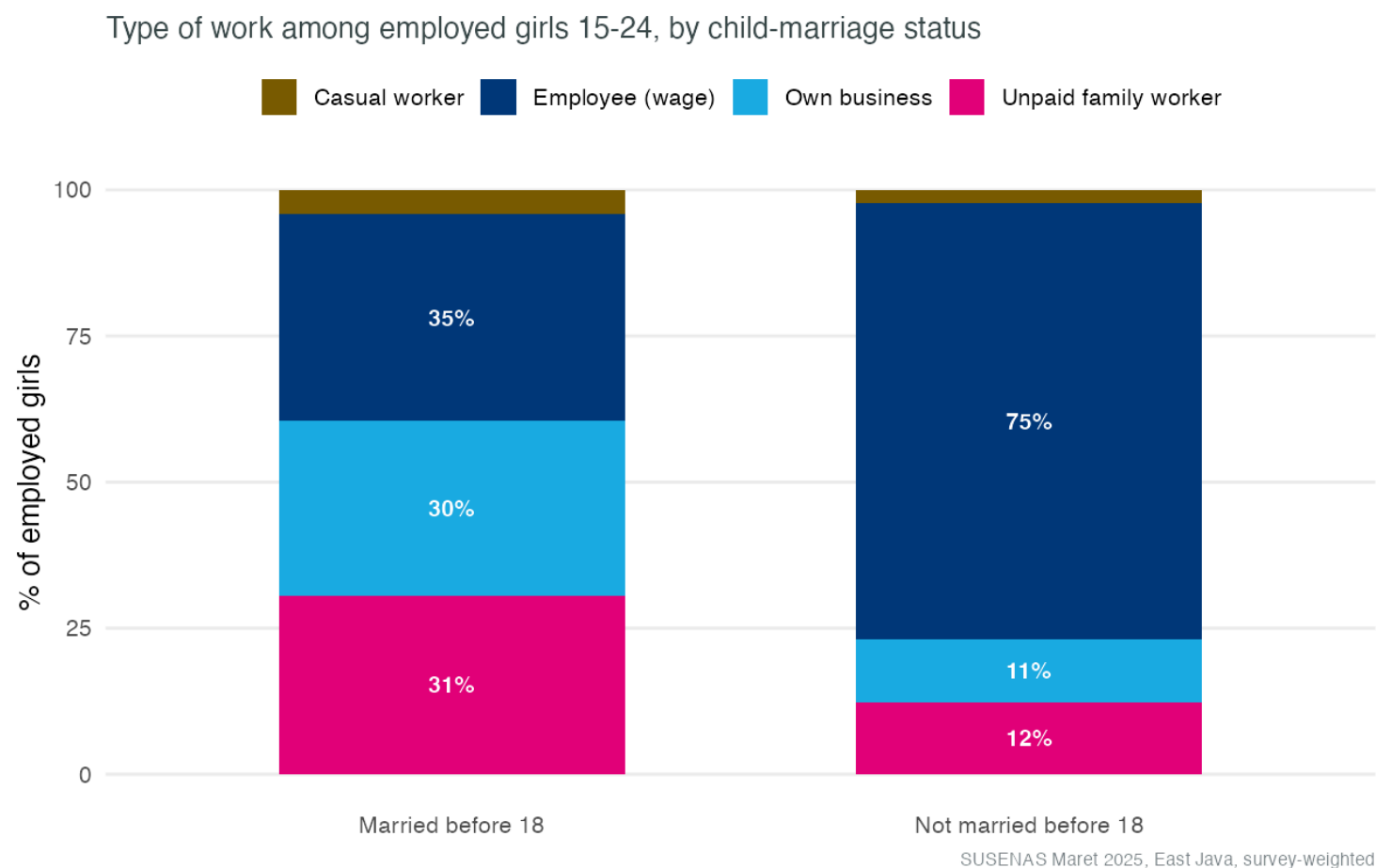


Girls' NEET is 34% in Madura (Bangkalan, Sampang, Pamekasan, Sumenep) against 22% in the rest of East Java; boys' NEET is 23% against 12%. The gender gap is similar (11 vs 10 points), and fewer girls are in school (45% vs 52%). Madura is a priority area for a pilot.

Girls married before 18 are much more likely to be NEET and out of school

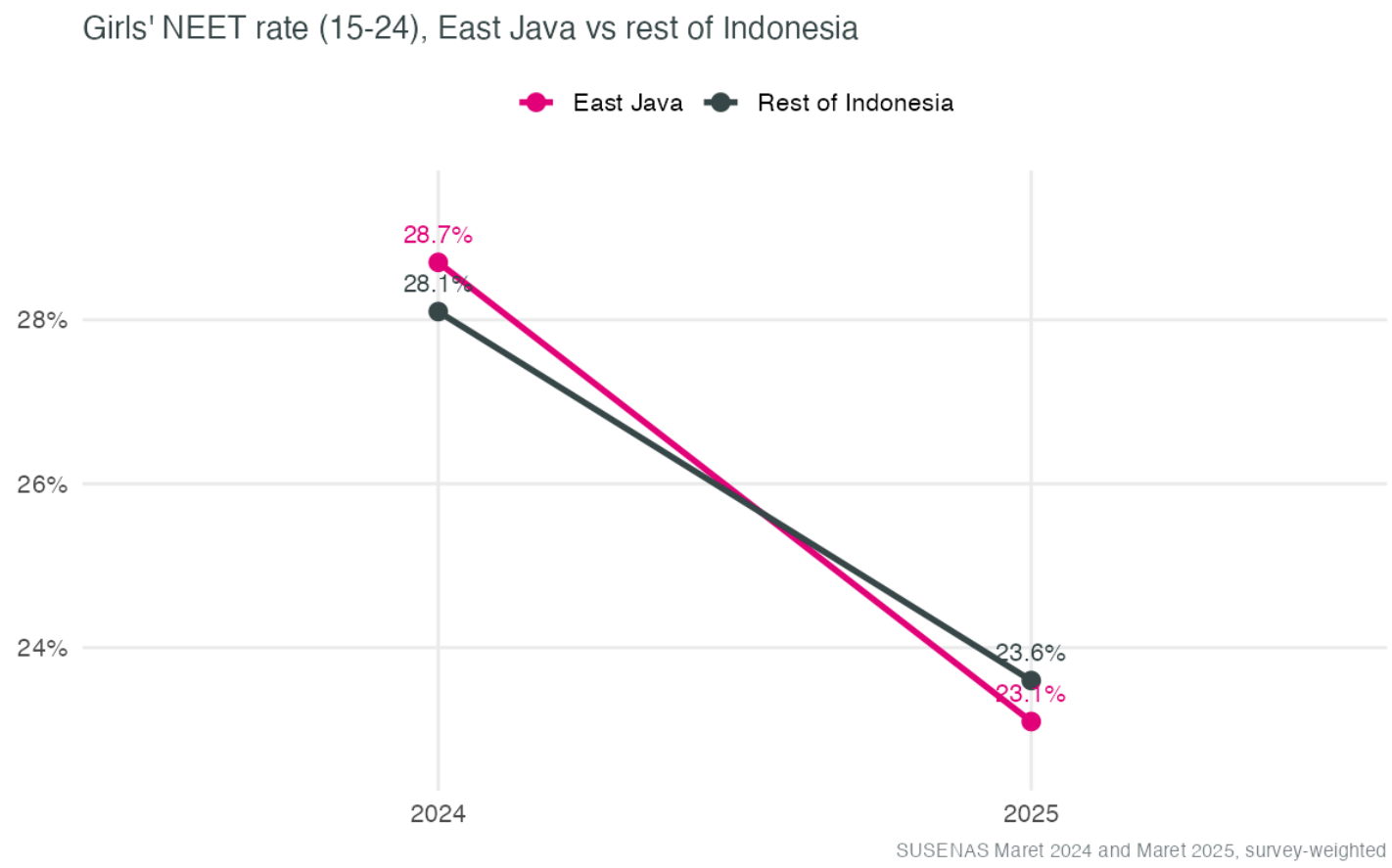


Married girls who work are mostly in unpaid family work or own businesses



Among employed girls married before 18, 35% are wage employees (others 75%) and 31% are unpaid family workers (others 12%); 22% work under 20 hours a week (others 12%). Their employment is lower-quality work. Based on 78 employed married girls, so indicative.

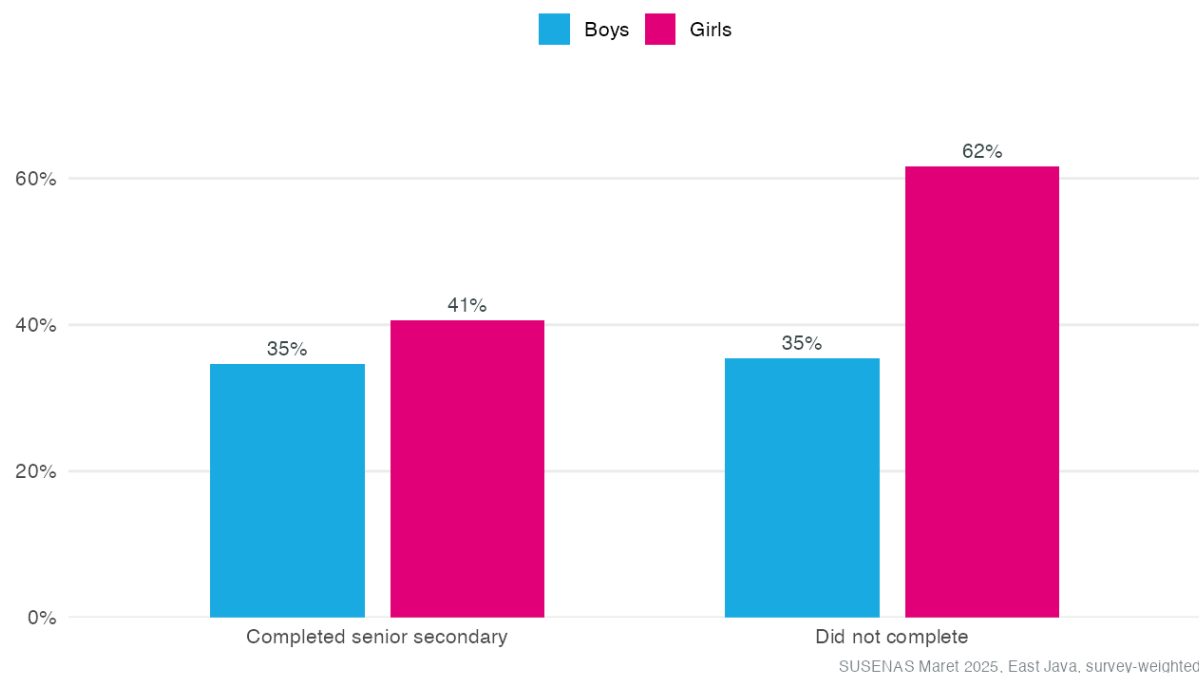
Girls' NEET fell from 2024 to 2025, slightly more than in the rest of Indonesia



2 · Theory of change

Completing senior secondary is associated with 20 points lower NEET for girls

NEET rate among 18-20 year olds who have left school, by senior-secondary completion



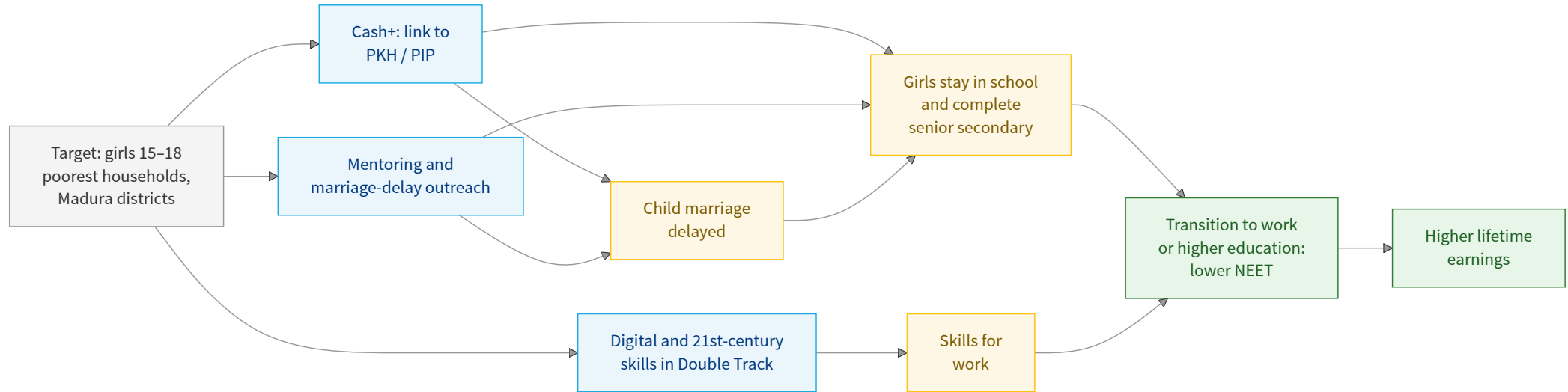
Among 18–20 year olds who have left school, girls who completed senior secondary have a NEET rate of 41%, against 62% for those who did not. Adjusted for age and area (girls 18–24), completion is associated with a 20-point lower NEET rate ($p < 0.001$). For boys there is no difference. Keeping girls in school to completion is the programme’s main lever.

Evidence from Indonesia

Programme	Design	Result	Relevance
PKH cash transfer (Priebe & Sumarto, 2025)	Quasi-experimental	Girls' junior-secondary enrolment +5.2pp; child marriage -3.5pp	A cash component reduces child marriage
PIP education assistance (Ulfa & Rezki, 2024)	Quasi-experimental	School attendance +11.4pp	Anchors the effect used in the ROI
PIP, girls' senior secondary (Caniago, 2021)	Quasi-experimental	Girls' senior-secondary enrolment +24.6pp	Targets the stage where girls drop out
Vocational training (Pritadrajati, 2022)	Quasi-experimental	Female LFPR +3.4pp; income +5.6%	Skills translate into work

In SUSENAS 2025, girls in PKH households have lower child-marriage rates than other girls (3% vs 4–6%), even though PKH targets poorer households. Consistent with the PKH evidence, though not a causal estimate.

Theory of change



Each link rests on evidence shown earlier: completion lowers NEET (20 points for girls), cash transfers reduce child marriage (PKH), and skills raise female employment (vocational training). The cash component links girls to existing PKH and PIP entitlements rather than creating a new transfer.

3 · Return on investment

Key assumptions

Assumption	Value	Source
Reduction in girls' NEET	5 points	PIP attendance effect (+11.4pp), 45% assumed to come from girls who would be NEET
Extra schooling for a girl kept in school	3 years	Senior-secondary cycle
Earnings gain per year of schooling	10%	Between SUSENAS consumption (5.6%) and IFLS5 wage (12%) estimates
Female earnings	Rp20 million/year	Below East Java minimum wage 2025, reflecting informal work
Female labour force participation	52%	Sakernas, East Java
Earnings growth / discount rate	2% / 3% per year	Career growth; World Bank education default
Programme cost	USD 200 per girl	USD 58 per year for 3 years, plus 15% overhead

Every USD 1 invested returns about USD 1.27

USD 1.27

return per USD 1 invested

USD 200

cost per girl (3 years)

3.9 pts

NEET reduction needed to break even (expected: 5)

USD 4002

cost per girl kept out of NEET

Returns count only girls' higher lifetime earnings. They exclude delayed child marriage, health, intergenerational and fiscal benefits, so they are a lower bound.

The return depends mainly on the programme's effect on NEET

Scenario	NEET cases averted per 1,000 girls	Benefit PV (USD/girl)	Cost (USD/girl)	BCR	Cost per NEET case averted (USD)
Lower effect (2.5pp)	25	127	200	0.63	8004
Central (5pp)	50	254	200	1.27	4002
Higher effect (7.5pp)	75	381	200	1.90	2668

With the effect held at 5 points and each other assumption varied one at a time, the return stays between USD 0.71 and USD 1.63 per USD 1 (appendix). The programme pays for itself if it reduces girls' NEET by about 4 points.

4 · Key messages

Key messages

1. Girls in East Java stay in school as long as boys but are close to twice as likely to be NEET, a wider gap than nationally. The gap costs about USD 4.1 billion in forgone lifetime productivity.
2. Madura is the priority area: NEET is higher for both sexes, and fewer girls are in school.
3. Child marriage is strongly associated with leaving school and with lower-quality work; poorer girls face higher risk.
4. Completing senior secondary is associated with 20 points lower NEET for girls, which makes school completion the programme's main lever.
5. A package of skills, mentoring and links to PKH/PIP costing about USD 200 per girl returns about USD 1.27 per USD 1 on earnings alone, and pays for itself if it reduces girls' NEET by about 4 points.

Appendix

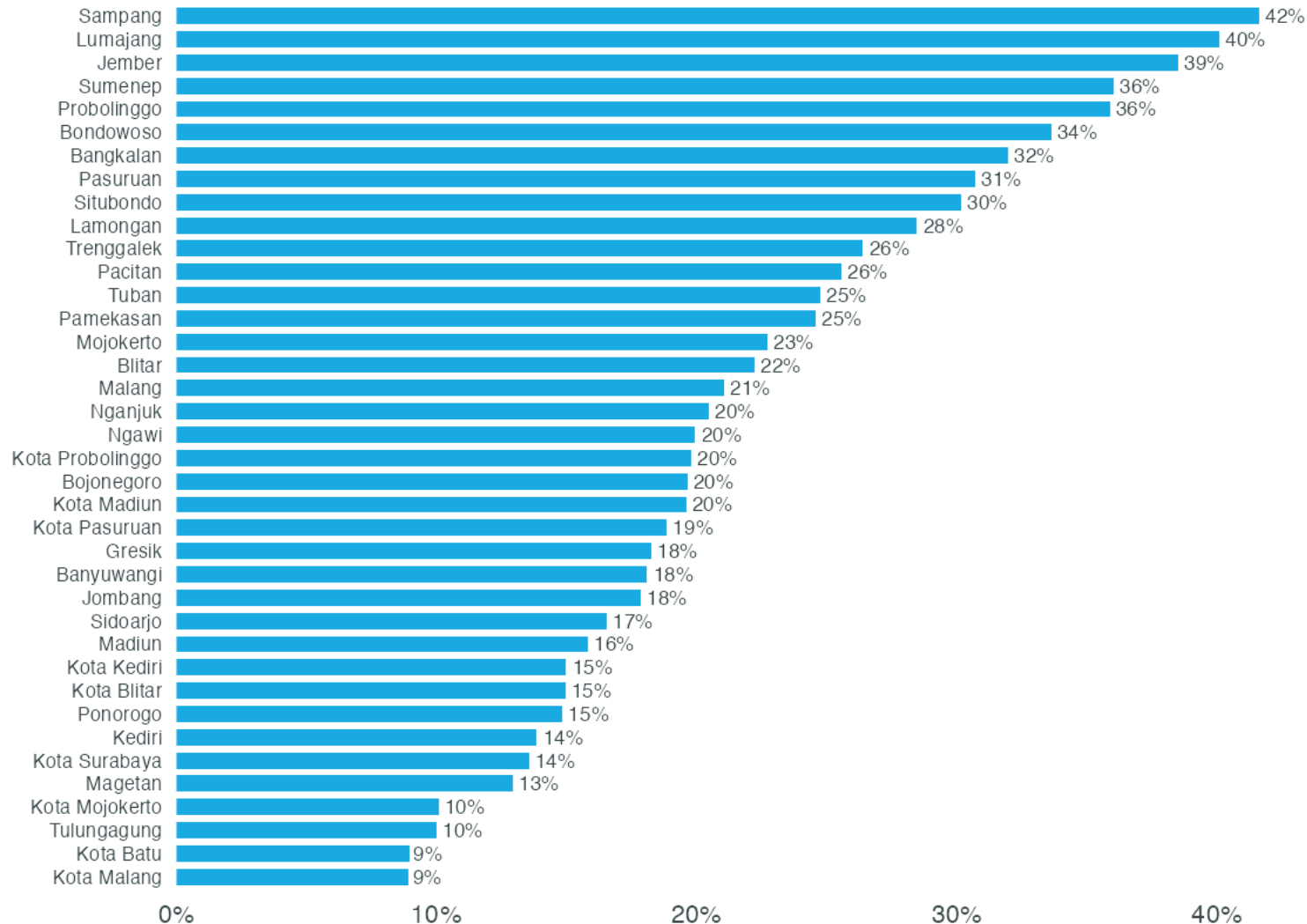
Regression results: child marriage and outcomes

Hypothesis	Effect (pp)	SE	p	N
Child marriage → NEET	28.7	4.6	0.0000	6060
Child marriage → in school	-27.5	3.0	0.0000	6060
Child marriage → employment	-1.2	4.6	0.7942	6060

Linear-probability models, girls 15–24, survey-weighted, PSU-clustered; controls for age and urban/rural (and poverty when expenditure data is available). Robust to district fixed effects. Association, not causation.

NEET among girls, by district

Girls' NEET rate, by East Java district (≥15 sampled girls)

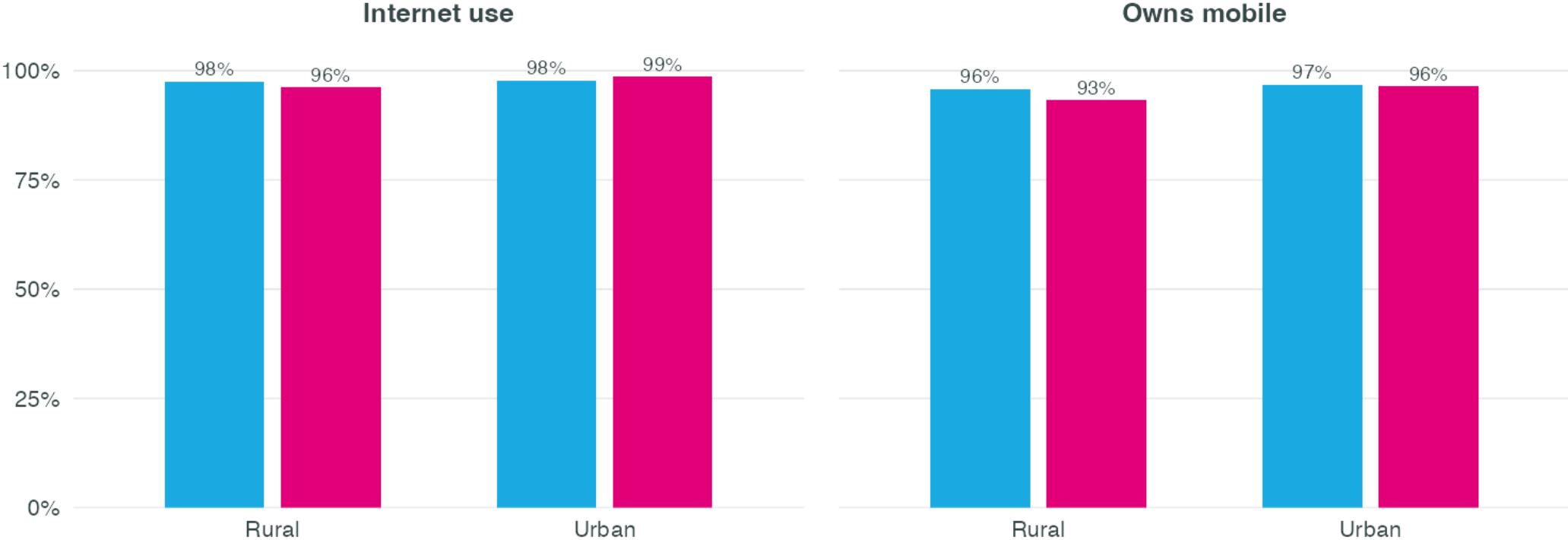


Source: SUSENAS Maret 2025 — East Java (prov 35). Weighted, adolescents 15–24.

Digital access and use

Digital access and use, by sex and area

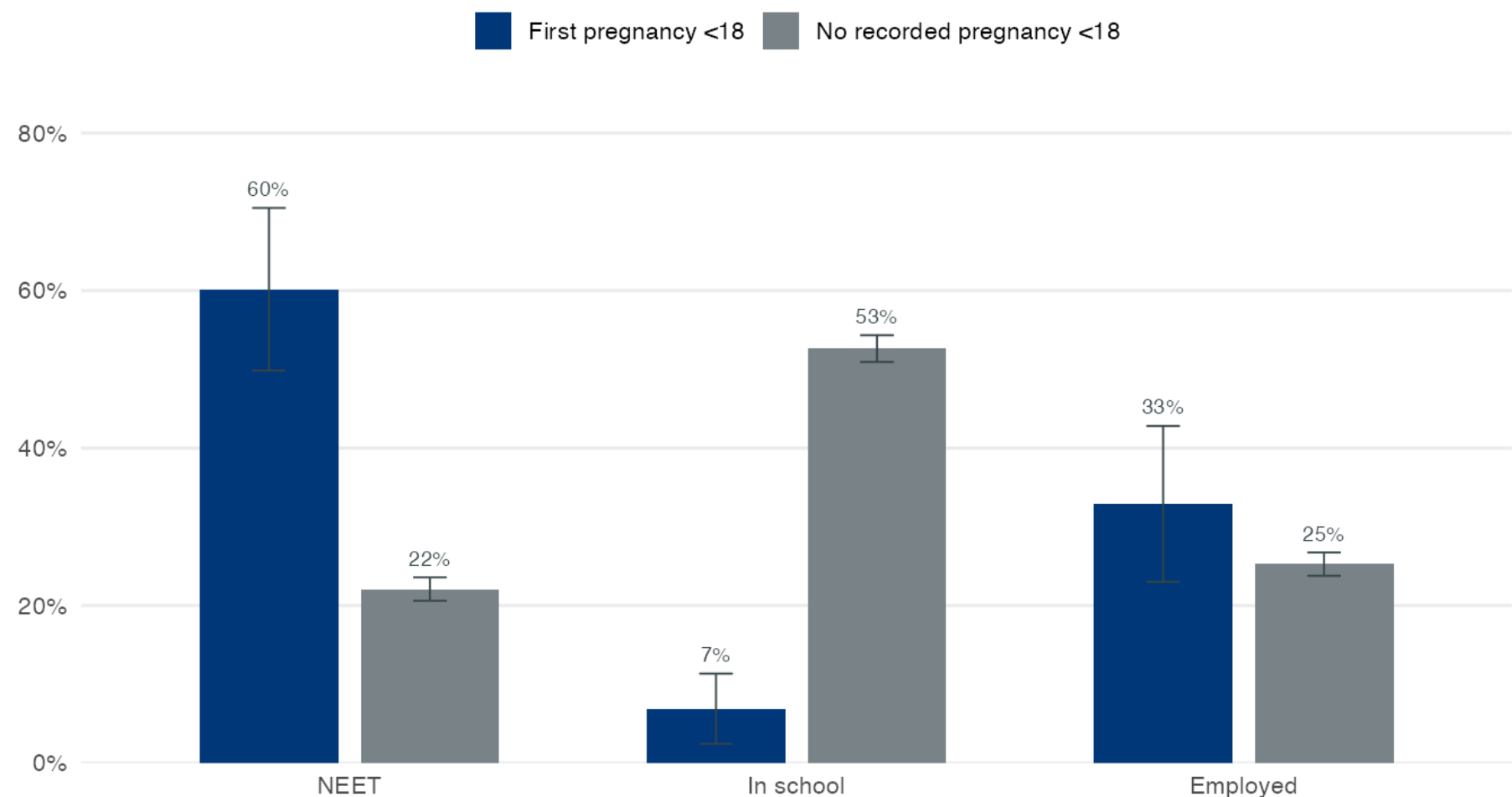
Boys Girls



Source: SUSENAS Maret 2025 — East Java (prov 35). Weighted, adolescents 15–24.

Early pregnancy and outcomes

Girls with an early pregnancy are far likelier to be NEET and out of school



SUSENAS Maret 2025 — East Java (prov 35) · girls 15–24; 95% CIs; lower bound (see note)

Recorded only for ever-married women, so a lower bound. Girls with a first pregnancy before 18 are almost all girls married before 18, so the main deck reports child marriage only.

Child marriage and NEET by household PKH receipt

region	PKH	n	Married_u18	NEET
Madura	Not PKH	509	6.1	35.9
Madura	PKH household	155	3.0	28.5
Rest of East Java	Not PKH	4661	4.1	22.1
Rest of East Java	PKH household	735	3.2	19.5

Girls 15–24, SUSENAS 2025. PKH targets poorer households, so lower rates among recipients are consistent with a protective effect, but are not a causal estimate.

Cost components

Component	USD/girl/yr
Digital content & platform	10
Teacher training (annualised)	15
Mentoring & socio-emotional	10
School connectivity/devices (shared)	15
Ancillary: marriage-delay + flexible learning	8
Annual direct cost per girl	58
Total per girl (3 years + 15% overhead)	200

Programme- and literature-benchmarked unit costs, using Indonesia-specific sources where available. Replace with Double Track actuals once provincial financing data are available.

Sensitivity of the return to each assumption

Parameter	BCR at low value	BCR at high value
NEET reduction per exposed girl	0.63	1.90
Mincer return per year of edu	0.71	1.52
Discount rate	0.86	1.56
Annual cost per girl (sensitivity)	1.63	0.98
Female annual wage (East Java)	0.95	1.59
Real earnings growth	0.94	1.49
Female labour force participation	1.10	1.46

Each assumption varied on its own, others held at central values.

What the return counts

Counted

Higher schooling leads to a lifetime earnings premium for girls moved out of NEET, using the female return to schooling over a discounted working life.

Excluded (so the return is a lower bound)

Delayed child marriage · health and productivity spillovers · intergenerational gains · fiscal returns · broader empowerment

Comparable international evidence

Programme	Design	Girls / age	Focus	Key result	Fit for East Java
Adolescent girls' wellbeing, Bergström & Özler 2021	Review (104 studies)	Adolescent girls	Multi-sector interventions	Integrated packages beat single-sector ones	Synthesis backbone for the ToC
NEET in Indonesia, Faizah, Isbah & Azca 2025	Qualitative	Youth (gendered)	Drivers of girls' NEET	Non-education factors (norms, care, marriage) drive girls' NEET	Indonesia-specific NEET context
ELA girls' clubs, Bandiera 2018 (Sierra Leone)	RCT	Girls 12–25	Vocational + life skills	Enrolment +8.5pp; more income-generating activity	Closest Skills4Girls-in-Double-Track model
Female digital-employment bootcamp, Alzúa 2020 (Argentina/Colombia)	RCT	Women 18–50	Coding for employment	Large coding-skill gains	Core digital-skills → jobs arm
Irumi, Näslund-Hadley 2025 (Paraguay)	RCT	Pupils	Computational thinking	+0.09 SD CT	Structured CT pedagogy
Robotics & Coding, Gülen 2025 (Turkey)	RCT	Girls 14–16	Robotics / coding	Higher STEM-career orientation	Girls' STEM, secondary age
Samata, Prakash 2019 (India)	RCT	Poor girls 13–16	Secondary-transition support	More girls transition; norm shift	South Asia; senior-secondary transition
Room to Read GEP, Edmonds 2021 (India)	RCT	Girls	Life skills + mentoring	Dropout –3.5 to –4.1pp	Mentoring/pedagogy layer cuts dropout
Negotiating a Better Future, Ashraf 2025 (Zambia)	RCT	Girls ~14	Negotiation skills	+0.26 years schooling (10-yr)	Durable, cheap soft-skills layer
OLPC / Plan Ceibal, de Melo 2014 (Uruguay)	Quasi / review	Pupils	Laptops (hardware-led)	Learning ≈ null (–0.05 SD)	Caution: hardware alone fails → fund pedagogy

The Mincer specification

$$\ln(Y_i) = \beta_0 + \beta_1 S_i + \beta_2 S_i^2 + \beta_3 \text{Age}_i + \beta_4 \text{Age}_i^2 + \beta_5 \text{Urban}_i + \varepsilon_i$$

- Y_i : monthly wage (IFLS5 earners 20–60) or household per-capita expenditure (SUSENAS)
- S_i : years of schooling, from highest certificate
- β_1 : return per additional year of schooling
- β_2 : positive and significant means returns rise with schooling level
- Weighted, with clustered or robust standard errors

Data and definitions

Source. SUSENAS Maret 2025 (all provinces; East Java: 98,738 individuals, 12,599 aged 15–24, of whom 6,060 girls) and SUSENAS Maret 2024 for the trend. Survey-weighted, PSU/strata-clustered.

- **NEET (15–24):** not attending school (R611) and not working (R703_A, R704).
- **Married before 18:** age at first marriage (R409) under 18.
- **Senior-secondary completion:** highest certificate (R615) at SMA/SMK/MA level or above.
- **Type of work:** status in main job (R706); hours (R707).
- **Madura:** Bangkalan, Sampang, Pamekasan, Sumenep.

The 2025 questionnaire replaced the single main-activity question with a multi-select block, so year-on-year changes partly reflect the new question; comparisons with the rest of Indonesia use the same definition in both places.

Data availability

Indicator	Status
NEET, schooling, employment, child marriage, digital access	Available, 2024 and 2025
Expenditure and official poverty	Available for 2024; 2025 consumption module not yet obtained
Disability	Not in 2024 or 2025; available in SUSENAS 2023
Earnings	Not in SUSENAS; IFLS5 used; Sakernas microdata requested
Higher-education field of study	Not in SUSENAS; PDDikti is the source
Programme districts and costs	Requested from UNICEF and the provincial government